

Dogma as Structure: A Philosophical Defense of Religious Norms

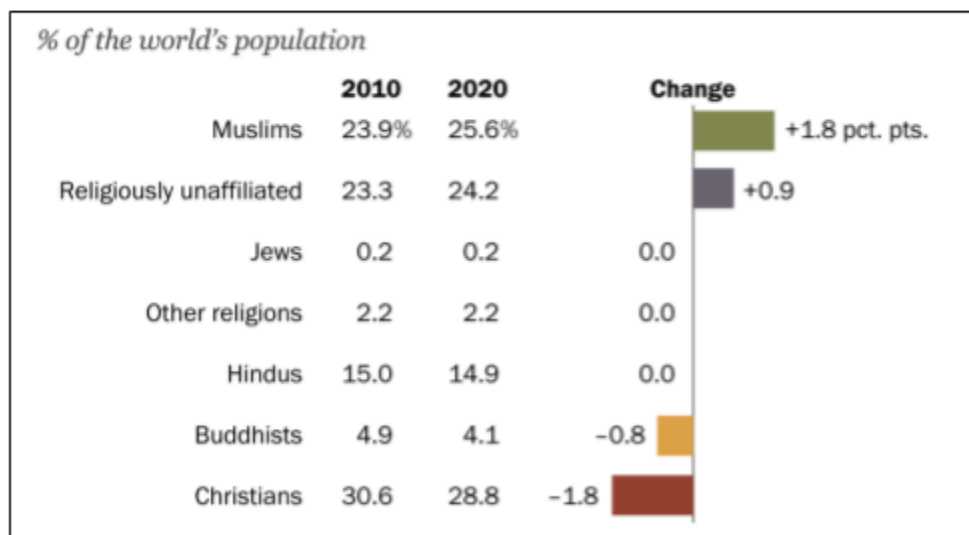
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Introduction

Why would the creator of a trillion galaxies become angry if you have sex with your boyfriend or eat bacon for breakfast? Religious norms, such as prohibitions on premarital sex and eating pork, are central to many faiths. This aspect of religion, which attempts to control personal behavior, often sparks cynicism and debate in today's secular societies. Globally, the proportion of religiously unaffiliated people grew from 23.3% in 2010 to 24.2% by 2020 (Hackett et al., 2025, Figure 1).

Figure 1

Population change of Religious groups from 2010 to 2020



Note. From Hackett, et al (2025, p. 9). *How the global religious landscape changed from 2010 to 2020.*

The religious "nones" view these dogmas as shackles and relics of a superstitious past. Richard Dawkins (2008) captures this perspective, claiming that religious norms require 'no justification and brook no argument' to enforce conformity (p. 308). The social media megaphone has amplified this skepticism, with young adults using the platforms to challenge religious authority and cheer personal freedom (Sjö, 2025; Kight, 2021). But anthropological evidence paints a more nuanced picture. These norms are not just restrictions but serve to strengthen communities, support family stability, and create cultural identities for billions (Boyer, 2001; Haidt, 2012).

Religious dogmas were rarely about divine micromanagement; they were, and remain, structures of moral meaning and collective discipline.

In an age of shifting moral values and divided secular beliefs, studying these norms shows their lasting role in fostering community and stability, refuting claims that they merely control behavior. Instead of dismissing these norms as oppressive, we can see them as vital structures that have long sustained community bonds and social stability.

Ritual Logic in a Rational Age

In the 21st century, secular cultures in the West often dismiss these prohibitions on premarital sex or eating pork as arbitrary relics of a premodern era. Richard Dawkins (2008) argues that religious norms suppress free thought with restrictive moral codes, but this view underestimates their historical role in fostering stable, meaningful communities. In early communities with little formal governance, these prescriptions served as ritual outlines that regulated behavior, reinforced shared identity, and preserved social stability.

Take the religious prohibition against premarital sex, derided as outdated in today's society. While these rules were framed as divine commands, they also met urgent practical needs in early societies, binding communities by eliciting commitment from men and reducing cheating. Jonathan Haidt (2012) shows how premarital sex, in tribal and agrarian societies, risked destabilizing inheritance systems by creating disputes over lineage and property. By enforcing strict norms against such behavior, religious communities strengthened family cohesion and prevented social conflict.

Religious dogma was not just a top-down command—it often served to protect the group from internal breakdown or social drift. Pascal Boyer (2001) complements this view, suggesting that such rules also cultivated moral intuitions, embedding ethical norms through repeated practice. These restrictions were not actually meant to be constricting, but in fact, cultural codes prioritizing needs over desires. The Hebrew Bible's rules were meant to stabilize fragile kinship systems, with early Christianity building on this by promoting abstinence and monogamy to elevate women's dignity, thereby restricting male dominance. Islam also enshrined marital boundaries to uphold communal honor and social integrity.

Likewise, restrictions on eating pork also have a practical purpose from an anthropological lens, despite being treated as a punchline in secular critiques of religion. Pigs in the Middle East were not adapted to desert life and were unable to acclimate to the heat without any way to lower their body temperature. Marvin Harris (1974) notes that pigs, ill-suited to arid Middle Eastern environments, competed with humans for scarce food resources, lacking secondary benefits like wool or milk. Pigs were inefficient animals, and banning them was an attempt at resource optimization by avoiding an ecological misfit.

Banning the consumption of pork acted as a tool of cultural differentiation for the Israelites. Pigs were especially popular among their neighbors, particularly the Philistines, so for the Israelites refraining from eating pork represented the rejection of the neighboring cultic practices. Leviticus 11:7's prohibition, as Jacob Milgrom (1998) explains, further distinguished Israelite identity from neighboring Philistine practices, reinforcing a covenantal distinctiveness. Islam inherited and expanded this tradition, framing pork as ritually impure and thus prohibited as a marker of obedience and a unifying cultural norm. While critics like Christopher Hitchens (2007) argue that such dietary laws reflect superstitious rigidity, their role in resource optimization and cultural differentiation suggests a pragmatic logic.

These examples illustrate that religious dogmas were not mere divine fiats but adaptive systems that balanced individual desires with collective needs. What appears irrational in modern society made profound sense in earlier contexts. While Haidt (2012) emphasizes social stability, Karen Armstrong (2009) underscores the emotional role of ritual. She notes that Logos, or reason, the pragmatic mode of thought that helps people function effectively in the world, has its limits. It cannot ease grief or help people find meaning in life's struggles. For that, people turned to mythos expressed through ritual and dogma. Religious dogma functioned—and continues to function—as a moral system when legal and scientific institutions were weak at best or absent altogether. These rules shaped behavior not through coercion alone, but through ritual repetition and collective reinforcement.

From Ritual Code to Moral Compass

Although contemporary societies have outgrown the environmental conditions that made the implementation of these restrictions necessary, the origins of these religious dogmas show that

religious traditions are repositories of human adaptation. Religious dogma still serves an important role, in the way that it binds belief to behavior, meaning to ritual, offering a moral compass in a society with more anxiety and fragmentation than ever. Viktor Frankl (2006) observed that even in the darkest conditions, such as his internment in concentration camps, people found the will to live through commitment to a person or purpose. Dogmas, despite their perceived rigidity, provide exactly that, taking abstract values and transforming them into lived practices. In an era of endless choices that often lead to emptiness, this grounding may be not only relevant but necessary, particularly as the decline of religious observance has not delivered the moral clarity anticipated by secular thinkers like Bertrand Russell (1957), who argued that rational ethics could replace religious frameworks. In place of sacred dogma, we now see a patchwork of ideologies, from pop psychology slogans to curated wellness trends. Each claims to offer, or even replace, what religion once was: identity, meaning, and moral guidance. However, these substitutes often lack coherence and continuity, key features that make religious dogma both binding and everlasting.

The rise of political beliefs as quasi-religions is one example of these fragmented ideologies. Political belief systems have taken on increasingly moralistic tones, complete with heresies, saints, sacred texts, and public rituals of denunciation. Charles Taylor (2007) notes that such ideologies, while fostering group identity, often prioritize outrage over introspection, lacking the humility embedded in religious dogmas.

Meanwhile, consumer capitalism offers a different version of meaning: self-expression through consumption. Whether through wellness brands, minimalist aesthetics, or self-optimization apps, individuals are encouraged to construct identity through vetted lifestyle choices, not commitments. Consumer capitalism promotes self-expression through consumption, as James K.A. Smith (2016) illustrates by likening shopping malls to secular liturgies that prioritize individual desire over societal obligation. Unlike religious rituals, which integrate individuals into shared moral foundations, consumerism fosters fleeting identities tied to material goods. Secular consumerism thrives on endless choice and remains an unhealthy move away from the dogma that promotes strong bonds.

Contemporary secular philosophies, such as secular humanism, which reject dogma, lack the emotional resonance and shared bonds that religion brings. Secular systems, though intellectually robust, do not have the historical and cultural depth that grounds religion in the collective psyche of communities. Charles Taylor (2007) argues that secular humanism lacks the ‘sacred canopy’ of religious traditions, limiting its communal resonance. Critics like Christopher Hitchens (2007) contend that religious dogmas enforce exclusionary norms, yet their capacity to create cohesive support systems, evident in religious congregations, remains unmatched by secular alternatives.

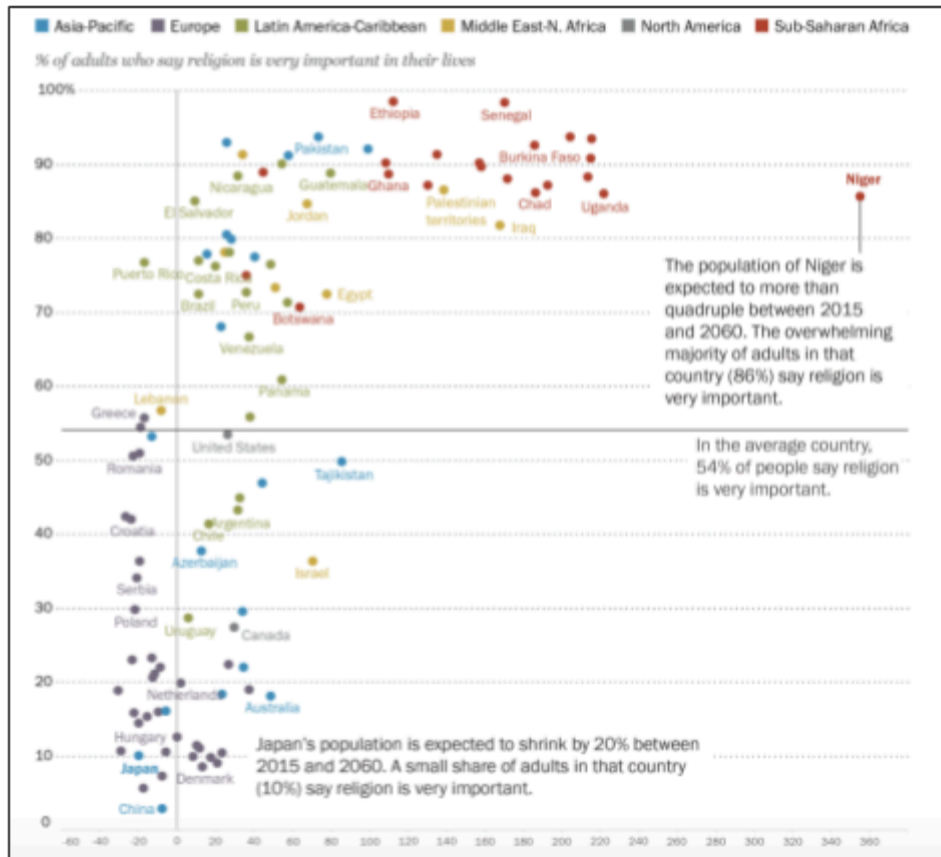
The result is a society filled with competing schemes for meaning—political, psychological, and consumerist—with few offering the moral system of traditional religion. While religion demands discipline, secular culture prioritizes personal desire.

Where religious dogma draws individuals out of themselves into sacred obligation, modern substitutes draw them further inward toward personal branding and curated authenticity. And so what is left is an endless cycle of superficiality and self-curation, unhealthy and destructive habits. This is not to romanticize all religious dogma, which has been a perpetrator of many oppressive, exclusionary, or inflexible ideals in the past. However, religion creates moral universes, not just preferences, by encoding identity in belief, practice, repetition, and sacrifice. The dogmas are precisely what give it durability, and history shows that when religious structures fall, they are not replaced by purely rational systems, but by new dogmas that are often far more volatile and less forgiving.

Conclusion

In an era of rising secularization, particularly in Western democracies where 24.2% of the global population identified as religiously unaffiliated by 2020 (Hackett et al., 2025), it is tempting to dismiss religious dogmas as relics of a bygone era. Still, critics like Dawkins miss the global population trends that show religious norms’ ongoing importance. While secular populations in Europe and North America grow older, sub-Saharan Africa, with its strong religious faith, sees rapid population growth from higher birth rates and younger people, as shown in Figure 2. 30.7% of the world’s Christians lived in sub-Saharan Africa by 2020 (Hackett et al., 2025). This growing population reflects the lasting importance of religious norms in guiding ethical and social life.

Figure 2
Projected Population Change of Countries from 2015-2060



Note. From Pew Research Center. (2018, June 13, p. 11). *The age gap in religion around the world*

Though Christopher Hitchens (2007) claims that religious norms foster divisive rules, their historical role in building steady frameworks for raising families, settling conflicts, and answering life's deeper questions reveals their greater value. Dismissing them as irrational oversimplifies their function as ritual systems, shaped by millennia of human trial and adaptation, as Karen Armstrong (2009) illustrates through the interplay of mythos and logos. These traditions offer a moral vocabulary that billions continue to rely on, particularly in regions where secular alternatives lack cultural traction. To neglect this complexity risks fostering a world rich in individual choice but poor in shared meaning, where obligation and social order are increasingly scarce.

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